The existence of a trigger event

In each of the four instances above, there was a very identifiable (at least with hindsight) trigger event, when existing prejudice spilled over into genocide. For the Ottomans in 1915 and the Soviets in 1941, the trigger was war and invasion. Both feared that a particular ethnic group would side with their invader and carried out massacres and forced deportation to reduce the risk of this happening. In Rwanda, the immediate trigger was the very suspicious air crash that killed President Habyarimana[31] (who had been seen by the Hutu hardliners as too keen on national reconciliation). The day after his death, the massacres commenced, showing a mixture of state organisation and inter-communal violence.

For the Nazis, there were two triggers that meant they shifted from systemic persecution (and limited murder) to mass murder. One was the invasion of the USSR, where German troops organised the mass killing of the Jewish population as soon as they occupied a region. The second was the US entry into the war at the end of 1941 as, up to this stage, Hitler had been keen to keep the United States out of the war and described the Jews as ‘hostages’ whose lives would be at risk if the war spread.[32]

We need to bear this in mind when considering contemporary events in Myanmar. The preconditions are in place, but so far there have been neither universal killings nor total expulsion. However, as we will explore in the next chapter, there are plenty of potential trigger points, ranging from the aftermath of the 2015 elections to a major natural disaster.

International impotence

The role of the wider international community is of importance in preventing genocides. Even authoritarian, insular states have some degree of international links and a need to maintain at least some good relations. As we saw previously, the Myanmar regime is keen to ensure it can make money and buy weapons, and, despite its reservations, has developed substantial international links to assist in these goals. This potentially gives the international community considerable leverage—if it is prepared to use it.

The four instances discussed above show the importance of international partners in restraining, or providing a free hand to, a state on